later, India under Rajiv Gandhi dispatched a frigate to the Seychelles, which helped to successfully avert a coup against left-leaning dictator France-Albert René. [40]

While the Mauritius and Seychelles cases involved only the threat of force, the Maldives intervention of 1988 was more than that. Operation Cactus involved India sending para commandos in two transport aircraft after the seizure of the capital Malé by about eighty Sri Lankan Tamil mercenaries. India's initial assault was complemented by additional forces from the Army, Air Force, and Navy. The operation, hastily planned and executed in sixteen hours with little intelligence support, was successful in its objective of restoring President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom to power. [41]

India's interventionist impulse was more muted, but not entirely absent, in Afghanistan and Nepal. In Afghanistan, India was a bit player for much of the 1980s as the country's civil war led to a Soviet invasion and a proxy conflict involving the United States, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan. New Delhi had been caught in an awkward position by the Soviet invasion of 1979–80 and had to balance its own close relationship with the USSR with its genuine frustrations at Moscow's move. In the latter half of the decade, Rajiv Gandhi forged a stronger relationship with the Soviet-backed Afghan leader Mohammed Najibullah. There was also greater intelligence cooperation with Afghanistan facilitated by the Soviet intelligence agencies. In the late 1980s, India continued to assist Najibullah even as his support dwindled, the Soviets withdrew, and rival forces neared the capital. After his fall in 1992, Najibullah lived in a UN compound in Kabul. When the Taliban took the city in September 1996, they had him seized, castrated, mutilated, and shot, and his body hanged in public. [42] It was a macabre sign of things to come.

If Afghanistan saw a devastating and brutal civil war during the 1980s, Nepal experienced political upheaval, sporadic violence, and embargoes. Much of this had to do with the consolidation of power of King Birendra. In 1987, Birendra opted to tilt closer to China and the next year he concluded a secret agreement for intelligence sharing with Beijing and began to acquire military supplies from China. Birendra also endorsed Chinese infrastructure